

Social Humanitarian and Cultural Committee

Protecting Human Rights and Cultural Heritage in the Digital Age.

Backgrounder Guide

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Director's Letter

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to the Social Humanitarian and Cultural Committee (SOCHUM) at the 2026 iteration of SPAMUN! My name is Erin, and I am beyond thrilled to serve as your Director alongside my Chair, Kaveer Lally, and my Assistant Director, Cayden Wang. On behalf of the entire Dais team, I'd like to issue a warm welcome to everyone and look forward to working towards our mission to foster sophisticated yet fruitful debates, giving all delegates, no matter whether it's your first or tenth conference, the best possible experience. I eagerly await meeting all of you in October and hope each and every one of you will have unforgettable experiences at SPAMUN 2026.

This iteration, SOCHUM will be addressing one of the most pressing challenges that has come up in the 21st century: balancing freedom of expression with regulation of online hate speech in the digital age. The constant yet rapid expansion of the internet, popularization of social media platforms, and development of online regulations have opened new avenues for foreign state and non-state actors to influence, destabilize, or manipulate political systems abroad.

Our task in this committee will be to examine the legal, political, and ethical challenges of this issue, to balance freedom of expression with regulations against hate. You will need to understand the nature of these platforms as well as the complex background rivalries that drive them. Ultimately, the goal is to determine how nations can safeguard their political sovereignty without isolating themselves from global collaboration.

Position papers are due on October 16th, 10 PM for final submission. Please submit your position papers to sochumspamun@southpointe.ca, including your full name and delegation. If you encounter any circumstances that may affect your ability to meet the deadline, please do not hesitate to contact us.

Sincerely,
Erin Sweeney

Committee Description

The Social, Humanitarian, and Cultural Committee (SOCHUM), also known as the Third Committee of the UN General Assembly, is one of the six central committees in the United Nations. Originally founded in 1945, SOCHUM was formally established to fulfill the United Nations mission of protecting human rights across the globe.

Presently, SOCHUM works towards addressing human rights, social development, and humanitarian issues. Some of these include the treatment of refugees, children's safety, and Indigenous issues. SOCHUM resolutions are non-binding and cannot enforce binding resolutions, such as deploying peacekeeping troops. However, SOCHUM can recommend guidelines for independent nations to adopt voluntarily.

Topic Overview

Online hate speech happens when individuals or groups use digital platforms to attack, demean, or incite hostility against people based on characteristics such as race, religion, ethnicity, gender, or nationality. Social media, messaging apps, and video platforms have made this kind of content faster to produce, easier to spread across borders, and harder for authorities to remove, particularly in recent years as algorithms reward content that provokes strong reactions. This problem challenges two principles that the international community believes are fundamental: the right to freedom of expression, protected under Article 19 of the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR), and the right to be free from discrimination and incitement to violence, which Article 20 of the same covenant requires states to prohibit. There is still no universally accepted United Nations definition of hate speech, which means states draw the line between offensive speech and unlawful speech in very different places.

Over the past decade, many countries have seen online hate speech lead to real-world negative impacts. In Myanmar, a 2018 UN Fact-Finding Mission concluded that Facebook played a determining role in spreading hatred against the Rohingya ahead of the violence of 2017, and the company later acknowledged it had not done enough to prevent this. In 2019, a gunman in Christchurch, New Zealand, livestreamed his attack on two mosques, and the video spread across platforms faster than they could remove it. This led New Zealand and France to launch the Christchurch Call to eliminate terrorist and violent extremist content online. Smaller states are often hit the hardest as platforms invest less in moderating content in local languages, leaving communities with fewer protections.

While it is common for governments to be urged to regulate harmful content more aggressively, history has shown that regulation itself can be a source of concern. Germany's Network Enforcement Act (NetzDG), introduced in 2017, required large platforms to remove clearly unlawful content within 24 hours or face fines of up to 50 million euros, and critics argued that this pushed companies to over-remove lawful speech to avoid penalties. The European Union's Digital Services Act has since created a broader framework of obligations for platforms. Meanwhile, human rights organizations have warned that vaguely worded laws against "hate speech" or "false information" have been used in several countries to silence journalists, political opposition, and minority groups. The United States, for its part, protects most hate speech under the First Amendment and entered a reservation to Article 20 of the ICCPR, showing how deeply divided states are on where the balance lies.

Given the possibility of fueling discrimination, inciting violence, and weakening public trust in both institutions and online spaces, the regulation of online hate speech must be addressed with care. This issue reaches far beyond the countries mentioned above, as both developed and developing countries are affected. Because most major platforms are privately owned and operate across many jurisdictions, no single government can solve the problem alone. The effects also extend past governments, as activists, journalists, and minority communities are frequently driven out of online spaces by harassment, which limits the very freedom of expression that regulation is meant to protect.

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Timeline of Events

December 10, 1948 – The Universal Declaration of Human Rights was adopted, with Article 19 enshrining freedom of expression as a fundamental right.

December 21, 1965 – The International Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Racial Discrimination (ICERD) is adopted, with Article 4 requiring states to criminalize incitement to racial hatred.

December 16, 1966 – The International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR) is adopted, protecting free expression in Article 19 while requiring states to prohibit incitement to hatred and violence in Article 20.

February 4, 2004 – Facebook is launched, going mainstream in the era of social media and transforming how people communicate, while also introducing challenges surrounding misinformation and hate speech.

February 14, 2005 – YouTube was founded, allowing users to upload and share videos worldwide and increasing concerns about extremist content and online hate speech.

March 15, 2006 – The United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC) was established, becoming a leading international forum for discussions on human rights, including freedom of expression in the digital world.

October 5, 2012 – The Rabat Plan of Action is adopted, giving states a six-part threshold test for deciding when speech becomes criminal incitement.

June 30, 2017 – Germany's Bundestag passes the Network Enforcement Act (NetzDG), requiring large platforms to remove unlawful content quickly or face heavy fines.

August 27, 2018 – The UN Fact-Finding Mission on Myanmar publishes its findings, concluding that Facebook played a significant role in spreading hatred against the Rohingya.

March 15, 2019 – A gunman livestreams an attack on two mosques in Christchurch, New Zealand, exposing how quickly violent content spreads across platforms.

May 15, 2019 – The Christchurch Call to Action is launched in Paris, bringing governments and tech companies together to eliminate terrorist and violent extremist content online.

June 18, 2019 – The UN Strategy and Plan of Action on Hate Speech is launched, giving the UN system its first coordinated framework for addressing the issue.

July 21, 2021 – The General Assembly adopts a resolution proclaiming June 18 the International Day for Countering Hate Speech.

November 16, 2022 – The European Union's Digital Services Act enters into force, creating binding content moderation and transparency obligations for online platforms.

September 22, 2024 – The Global Digital Compact is adopted as part of the Pact for the Future, including commitments to address online hate speech while protecting human rights.

Historical Analysis

Historically, nations exerted control and influence through spying, propaganda, and sabotage. However, in the early 1980s, the rise of digital technologies introduced new strategies of interference that fundamentally changed international relations. For the past 2 decades, technology, the internet, surveillance systems, and cyber warfare have become central tools of foreign political interference. As these technologies continue to evolve, foreign digital interference is becoming sophisticated and adaptive, making it increasingly difficult to detect, prevent, and defend against.

In the early 2000s, cyber espionage emerged as a dominant form of foreign political interference during the development stage of the modern computer. Governments and intelligence agencies would rely on data-breaching software, malware, and even phishing attacks for lethal information from rival nations. Due to the limited cybersecurity and weak data protection at the time, cyber espionage was widespread. One of the notable cases was Moonlight Maze, being the most severe and longest-running cyber espionage case in world history. As a result, the government of Russia's operations stole a vast amount of classified information, documents, and codes.

The first social media platform was created in 1980, but it was not until 2010 that social media and information warfare bloomed. The invention of X (Twitter), YouTube, and Facebook gained popularity, and it opened doors for foreign actors. The strategies most used are disinformation campaigns, bot networks, troll farms, and targeted advertising. In 2016, Russian government operatives conducted foreign interference in the United States presidential elections. The interference was set for the victory of candidate Donald Trump by promoting and boosting his campaign. The Russian internet research agency created millions of troll farms on social media applications that spread disinformation about candidate Hilary Clinton. The foreign political interference strategies had a strong impact on U.S. citizens, leading to the success of President Donald Trump in the presidential election in 2016.

In 2020, foreign interference tactics became more advanced and dangerous because of the rise of artificial intelligence. Deepfakes are AI-generated hyper-realistic digital images able to change our perception of our world. Humans have few ways to determine deepfakes, such as audio calls that mimic people’s voices or video personas. The algorithmic manipulation exploits technology

programmes efficiently and quickly, making deepfakes hard to catch. During the U.S. presidential election in 2016 and 2020, deepfake videos of Kim Jong Un and Vladimir Putin were created. The foreign interference deepfakes warned U.S. citizens to save the election, implying that they should abstain from voting for President Donald Trump. The activist responsible for the deepfake aimed to send her message across the United States, having politicians state the note, which brought attention to the matter. The U.S. has responded 2 times by cancelling news outlets and channels to stop the advertisement of the deepfake.

Immediately, we are facing a crisis in warfare, with state-sponsored cyber operations interfering with political independence worldwide. Foreign interference is a key factor in hybrid warfare, including gaining knowledge of military information or cyber tactics. This heavily disrupts the political stability of countries, affecting election infrastructure, leaking obtained information, and influencing media outlets. Countries like the Democratic Republic of Congo are preparing for the 2026 pre-election to prevent disinformation and foreign political interference from Rwanda, experienced since the independence of the DRC. The European Union aims to empower Congolese journalists during the election, using round-table tactics to beat media disinformation and manipulation.

Early international commitments

Canada's climate-policy history predates the current debate over carbon pricing and net-zero targets. The country participated in the creation of the UNFCCC in 1992 and subsequently ratified the Kyoto Protocol. The Kyoto period demonstrated a recurring feature of Canadian climate politics: international commitments can be negotiated at the federal level while implementation depends on a country with substantial provincial authority over energy and natural resources.

Under Kyoto, Canada committed to an average emissions level 6% below 1990 during the 2008–2012 commitment period. Canada did not meet this objective and withdrew from the protocol in 2011, with withdrawal taking effect in 2012. The episode continues to influence debates over the credibility of federal climate commitments. Supporters of stronger federal action cite the history as evidence that targets require enforceable domestic policies. Critics can point to the same history as evidence that international commitments are difficult to meet when domestic economic and regional conditions change.

The Paris Agreement and the shift to net-zero

The Paris Agreement took a different structure from Kyoto. It established a framework in which all Parties submit nationally determined contributions, or NDCs, and progressively strengthen them. NDCs are submitted every five years and are informed by the results of the Paris Agreement's Global Stocktake.

Canada's first Paris target was a 30% reduction below 2005 levels by 2030. In 2021, the target was increased to 40–45%. The same year, Parliament passed the Canadian Net-Zero Emissions Accountability Act. The Act requires the federal government to establish emissions targets at least ten years in advance for five-year milestone years, prepare emissions reduction plans, publish progress reports, and maintain a framework for accountability toward net-zero by 2050.

The legislation matters because it separates the existence of a target from the specific policy instruments used to meet it. Parliament can set a long-term destination while successive governments decide how to regulate, tax, subsidize, or otherwise influence economic behaviour. That separation gives the framework continuity across electoral cycles, though it does not eliminate political disagreement about the policies themselves.

Carbon pricing

Carbon pricing became a central component of Canadian climate policy after 2018. The federal system was designed around two principal mechanisms. The first was a fuel charge applied to fossil fuels used by consumers and businesses in covered jurisdictions. The second was the Output-Based Pricing System, which applies to large industrial facilities and requires them to compensate for emissions above facility-specific limits while allowing facilities that outperform their limits to earn credits.

The economic logic of carbon pricing is relatively simple. Greenhouse gas emissions create a cost that is not fully reflected in the private price of fossil fuels. A price on emissions changes incentives by making high-emitting activities more expensive relative to lower-emitting alternatives. Industrial output-based systems use a different structure from a simple tax because they are designed around emissions intensity and trade exposure, with the goal of reducing emissions while limiting the risk that production moves to jurisdictions with weaker rules.

Carbon pricing nevertheless became one of Canada's most politically divisive climate policies. Supporters argued that it provided a broad and technology-neutral incentive to reduce emissions, while critics argued that consumer-facing pricing increased costs for households and businesses. The federal government ended the consumer fuel charge in April 2025. The industrial component remained, and the federal government subsequently shifted its carbon-pricing framework toward industrial emissions.

Sectoral regulation and investment

Carbon pricing was never Canada's only climate instrument. Federal policy has also targeted electricity, transportation, methane, fuels, buildings, industrial technology, and natural resources. This reflects the practical reality that different sectors respond to different policy tools.

Electricity is particularly important because decarbonizing electricity can enable reductions in other sectors. Electric vehicles, heat pumps, industrial electrification, and some forms of hydrogen production can reduce emissions when the electricity used to power them is low-carbon. Canada already has a relatively low-emitting electricity system compared with many countries because of hydroelectricity and nuclear power, but the national picture varies sharply by province. Federal Clean Electricity Regulations are intended to move the system toward net-zero emissions while providing flexibility for reliability and regional conditions.

Transportation is another major source of emissions. Policies have included fuel standards, zero-emission vehicle measures, public transit investments, and infrastructure support. The debate over transportation policy often combines climate goals with affordability, charging infrastructure, industrial policy, and the availability of vehicles in rural and remote areas.

Methane has received increasing attention because methane is a potent greenhouse gas over shorter time horizons. Canada has regulations and programs aimed at reducing methane emissions from oil and gas operations, and the federal government has committed to further methane reductions as part of the Global Methane Pledge.

Oil and gas policy

Oil and gas is the most politically sensitive sector of Canada's climate policy. It is also the country's largest source of greenhouse gas emissions. In 2022, the sector accounted for approximately 31% of Canada's GHG emissions, according to Environment and Climate Change Canada. It is simultaneously a major contributor to Canada's GDP, exports, employment, government revenues, and regional economies.

The federal government proposed an oil and gas emissions cap in 2023 and published draft regulations in 2024. The proposed system was designed as a cap-and-trade framework. It would limit the number of emissions allowances available to covered facilities while allowing certain compliance flexibilities, including offsets and other eligible units. The proposal was designed to cap emissions rather than production.

The policy subsequently became a point of uncertainty. Parliamentary records from 2026 refer to the federal government's decision not to proceed with the proposed oil and gas emissions cap regulations. This change illustrates how climate policy can shift as governments balance emissions targets with energy security, investment, economic competitiveness, and changing international conditions.

Federalism and regional differences

Canadian climate policy cannot be understood without federalism. Provinces and territories control or influence major sources of emissions, especially electricity and natural resources. Provincial climate policies vary considerably. British Columbia has historically used a carbon tax, Quebec operates a cap-and-trade system linked with California, Alberta uses an industrial pricing system, and other provinces have adopted different combinations of regulations, taxes, and incentives.

These differences cut both ways. Provinces can design policies suited to their economies, but national emissions targets require aggregate reductions across the country. Federal standards can establish a national floor, but federal intervention may produce disputes over jurisdiction. Climate policy often involves equivalency agreements, federal benchmarks, fiscal transfers, and negotiations between Ottawa and provincial governments.

Indigenous peoples and climate policy

Indigenous peoples are affected by climate change and climate policy in distinct ways. Many Indigenous communities are located in northern, rural, and remote regions where climate impacts can directly affect housing, transportation, food systems, infrastructure, and traditional activities. Indigenous governments and organizations are also involved in renewable energy, conservation, land stewardship, and resource development.

The Canadian Net-Zero Emissions Accountability framework requires consideration of Indigenous Knowledge in the climate accountability process, and internationally, the Paris Agreement recognizes the importance of Indigenous peoples' rights and participation. Climate policy raises questions about consultation, consent, economic participation, Indigenous-led projects, and the distribution of climate finance.

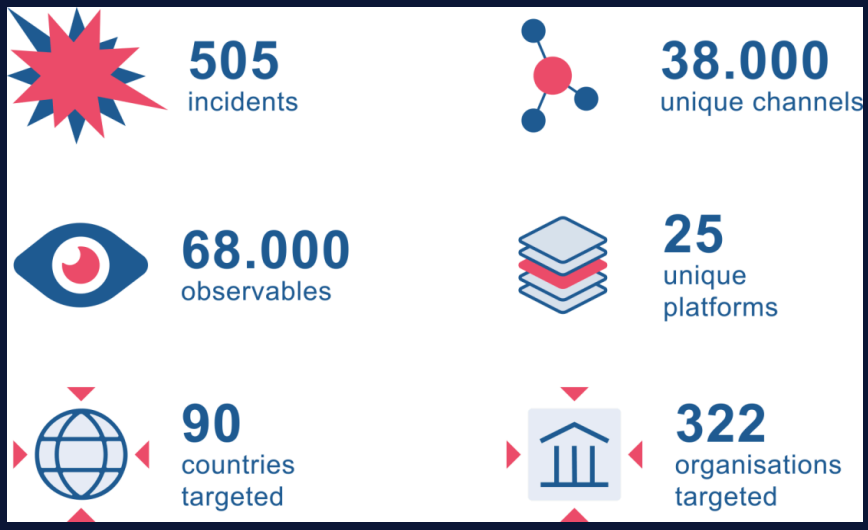
Current Situation

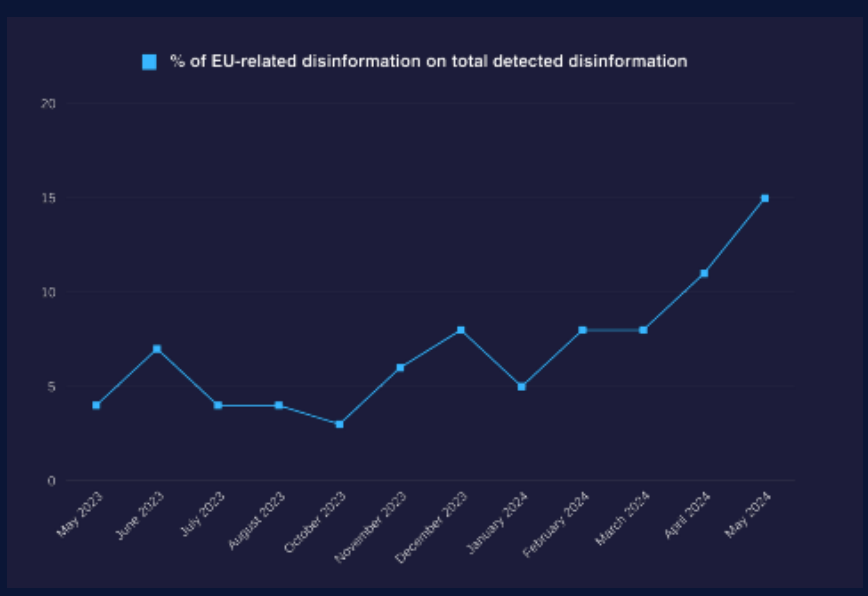
Today, there is rapid growth in technological advancement and dependency worldwide. Through expansions in artificial intelligence, cloud computing, and automation. Society is increasingly interconnected with technologies in our everyday lives, making the programmes more complex to keep up with our rapid evolution. Technological advancement benefits the economic development of countries, industries, technologies, and decision-making. Allowing indirect management of daily tasks or larger jobs, diminishing expenses. In addition, the government and corporate surveillance of the population, to ensure the security or manipulation of the citizens.

The rapid growth of technology, such as AI and ICT, within today's world has allowed foreign states and organizations to organize clandestine influence operations that are cheaper, more efficient, and extremely dangerous, as they pose a detrimental threat to a country's political independence and sovereignty. These operations, ranging from covert funding, AI-generated media, or foreign-controlled apps, can manipulate political discussions and undermine a country's democratic process through a multitude of methods, primarily through disinformation.

Major platforms and social media currently involved, such as TikTok, X, and Meta, have dealt with issues of AI spreading deceptive misinformation on their platforms in the past, with some being traced to state actors such as China, in an effort to deceive the public in an election. In 2024, for example, Meta, which owns and operates several large social media platforms such as Facebook, took down around 20 covert influence operations around the world leading up to the 2024 US presidential election. These disruptions were accompanied by AI imitations of the presidential candidates as well as fake accounts that were targeted at citizens to sway public opinion, potentially amplifying harmful narratives and shaping election discourses. In addition to this, operations created by Russia employed AI to imitate news websites such as Fox News in an attempt to weaken Western support for Ukraine, along with fake accounts that were used to manipulate public debate leading to the US election.

To evaluate the exact impacts of foreign technological interference, the EU External Action Service conducted a report on FIMI (Foreign Information Manipulation and Interference Threats), which maps out the digital infrastructure deployed by foreign actors, mainly Russia, to manipulate and undermine democratic processes and societies by spreading disinformation. This report revealed that over 500 FIMI incidents took place in 2024 and were spread across 90 different countries, accompanied by at least 25 different platforms being involved.





In another study done by the European Digital Media Observatory, it was revealed that in the last months before the elections, EU-related disinformation increased from 5% to 15% over the span of a few months, which was the highest among the monitored topics.

Apart from countries in the EU, nations such as Canada have also been targeted numerous times in attempts to affect the results of upcoming elections. For example, foreign states, including India, Russia, and China, have interfered with the country's democratic institutions out of interest for personal gain, as revealed in a report released by the head of the Foreign Interference Commission based on the testimony of more than 100 witnesses.

Currently, it's extremely evident that with the development of modern ICTs and AI technology, numerous threats and security risks arise that could potentially harm a nation's sovereignty and

political independence. Major powers are still debating what constitutes a “breach” or “interference”, considering the escalation of this issue today, which requires laws and frameworks to be refined and established to avoid these risks. Thus, national agencies and regional bodies such as the EU have been strengthening their defences to ensure no foreign interference takes place; however, international cooperation is instrumental in the development of frameworks that can help ensure this issue is addressed.

UN/International Involvement

Foreign Technological Interference and its Threat to Political Independence has been constantly talked about within the UN General Assembly and all of its committees, with a strong emphasis on technologies such as ICTs (Information and Communication Technologies), and their capabilities in reshaping economies, societies, and international relations. With these immense benefits come risks, as there has steadily been an increase in the malicious use of ICTs, which has posed a massive threat to all States when it comes to harming international sovereignty and political independence. Therefore, numerous NGOs, regional organizations, and the United Nations have been involved in efforts to address this growing challenge.

While SPECPOL does not draft binding resolutions specifically on security threats, the Fourth Committee has still played an important role in forwarding resolutions drafted by other committees of the General Assembly that have addressed Foreign Technological Interference, with an emphasis on the political and communications aspect. An example of SPECPOL's heavy involvement would be Agenda item 53, *Questions relating to information*. This agenda item has proposed draft resolutions addressing the dual challenge of combating misinformation while also ensuring access to information and journalism. Part A of the draft resolution promoted the idea and importance of countering misinformation by strengthening media literacy, while also enhancing international cooperation between developed and developing countries to strengthen communications technology and media infrastructure that is accurate and informative. Part B, *United Nations Global Communications Policies and Activities,* provided suggestions and guidance for the Department of Global Communications to address the increasing spread of misinformation, while at the same time not limiting the important role that ICTs can play in developing countries. (still needs more on the impact of these measures)

Possible Solutions

International Norms and Standards:
The first possible solution is to create general international norms that define what unacceptable technological interference is. Such standards would prohibit cyberattacks against electoral systems, state-sponsored spying into political parties, and intentional spreading of disinformation to destabilize foreign governments. By establishing standards in the United Nations, states would have a framework upon which they could hold one another accountable and reduce uncertainty about what action crosses the line. The main disadvantage of the approach, however, is that enforcement would be insecure because accused states will not admit fault, and powerful actors may oppose binding commitments.

Cybersecurity and Capacity Building:
Another method for SPECPOL is to facilitate capacity-building programs that allow vulnerable states to improve their ability to defend themselves. Developing states lack the technical expertise or economic capacity to maintain capable cybersecurity. Assistance could take the form of training election officials, provision of secure communications hardware, and the funding of infrastructure improvements. It would level the playing field between technologically advanced states and states with lower development. The issue is donor politics and cost, because wealthier states can use aid as leverage to become stronger or pursue their agendas.

Information-Sharing and Early Warning Systems:
Delegates can also consider creating information-exchange channels between governments, NGOs, and IGOs regarding cyberattacks and disinformation campaigns. Having a unified platform to monitor digital threats could allow nations to sense interference sooner and respond in a better manner. Such systems would also have the capacity to validate foreign interference claims. The drawback of the approach is that states will not release sensitive intelligence since they do not wish their vulnerabilities to be revealed, or due to distrust of rival governments.

Diplomatic Accountability:
SPECPOL can recommend the use of political and diplomatic tools that increase transparency and accountability in suspected interference. Instead of sanctions or binding actions, this can be

accomplished through General Assembly resolutions condemning interference, calling for states to publish reports on cyber threats, or supporting independent UN reporting documenting incidents without actually sanctioning states. These measures raise the political cost of intervention by focusing world attention upon perpetrators while remaining within SPECPOL's remit as a recommendatory institution. The drawback of this measure is that it will have a high reliance upon voluntary compliance, and states suspected of interfering will be able to wave off actions in these terms as politically motivated or biased.

Public Awareness and Media Resilience
Finally, long-term solutions may involve strengthening the ability of societies to resist disinformation itself. This may include promoting independent media, demanding fact-checking organizations, and supporting media literacy efforts to provide citizens with an easier ability to identify fallacies. By making citizens more knowledgeable, foreign influence would have less impact on political stability. The disadvantage of this solution is that it takes a very long time to develop, and non-democratic regimes would not be willing to accept such programs as foreign meddling in internal affairs.

Bloc Positions

Western / Democratic Bloc

- Australia – Strongly condemns interference, aligns with the U.S. and allies on cybersecurity norms; heavily targeted by Chinese cyber espionage.
- Canada – Prioritizes election security and countering disinformation; backs international cooperation and capacity-building through the UN.
- France – Seeks strong EU-wide regulation against disinformation (Digital Services Act) while protecting democratic processes.
- Germany – Supports EU regulations and NATO frameworks; wary after revelations of U.S. spying (Snowden leaks).
- Japan – Close U.S. ally; emphasizes protecting democracy from foreign disinformation, especially from China and North Korea.

- Republic of Korea (South Korea) – Faces frequent cyberattacks from DPRK; supports stronger cyber norms and international cooperation.

- United Kingdom – Post-Brexit, maintains strong alignment with U.S./NATO; invested in countering Russian disinformation.

- United States – Pushes for binding international norms against foreign interference; maintains global leadership on cybersecurity but is criticized for surveillance practices.

- Ukraine – Strongly advocates action against Russian disinformation and hybrid warfare; pushes for more robust enforcement.

Authoritarian / Sovereignty Bloc

- Belarus – Aligns with Russia; supports "cyber sovereignty" and rejects Western interference accusations.

- China – Promotes "cyber sovereignty" and strict state control of information; rejects Western accusations while expanding global digital influence.

- Cuba – Opposes Western "information imperialism," emphasizing sovereignty and state-controlled media.

- Democratic People's Republic of Korea (North Korea) – Uses cyber operations as a state tool (espionage, finance hacks); rejects international oversight.

- Iran – Uses cyber influence operations regionally; emphasizes sovereignty and non-interference.

- Russia – Rejects all interference accusations while being a major actor in disinformation; backs sovereignty-first approaches.

- Syria – Supports the Russia/China bloc; emphasizes sovereignty and rejects Western-imposed frameworks.

- Venezuela – Blames foreign interference (esp. U.S.) for instability; aligns with Russia and China on sovereignty.

Non-Aligned / Swing Bloc

- Brazil – As a BRICS member, it balances sovereignty with concerns about election interference; critical of Western firms like Cambridge Analytica.

- Democratic Republic of Congo – Highly vulnerable to disinformation; seeks foreign support to strengthen election security and media resilience.

- India – Promotes "strategic autonomy"; cautious about binding norms but supports global frameworks if they respect sovereignty.

- Indonesia – Advocates non-interference; vulnerable to disinformation; pushes for ASEAN-led approaches.

- Mexico – Wary of U.S. influence; interested in protecting electoral sovereignty but cautious about binding commitments.

- South Africa – As part of BRICS, it aligns with sovereignty-first principles but supports capacity-building for African states.

- Turkey – Plays a middle role; NATO member but also cooperates with Russia; favours sovereignty but opposes interference in domestic politics.

- United Arab Emirates – Prioritizes sovereignty and stability; wary of disinformation campaigns in the Middle East but avoids binding international restrictions.

Discussion Questions

1. To what extent does foreign technological interference violate state sovereignty as outlined in the UN Charter?
2. How can the digital divide between developed countries and developing nations be addressed to ensure that all countries have equal capacity to defend themselves from technological interference?
3. What frameworks can be adopted to combat misinformation and disinformation during elections without interfering with freedom of expression and the press?
4. How should the international community define and distinguish between cyber diplomacy and illegal technological manipulation?
5. How do geopolitical rivalries contribute to foreign technological interference?

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